We also came with suspicions and prejudices about our peers. But we all had to tackle our dogmas, partly in appreciation of the tremendous diversity of ideas and energies in the Yatra and partly because of the exceptional group of people that we had the honour of walking and working with. Like Mahatma Gandhi once taught the party, we learnt to check our own perceptions, accommodate differences and see our peers as a reflection of ourselves. There were undoubtedly those who imposed their views, refused to compromise and conducted themselves in a self-serving manner (whether in seeking publicity, clamouring for access to the party leadership, trying to ring-fence Rahul Gandhi or excluding energies and people), as R. Sudha alludes to in her article. But I think most of us organically accepted that everyone had something unique to offer, and the only way to further our shared goals was to work collaboratively and consensually. We learnt to embrace the inherent contradictions in human nature and not see everything in black and white; we learnt to share responsibilities without fretting about credit; and we accepted that penultimately the Yatra (and ultimately everything we were doing) was about the people.

This may be an excessively romanticized view of the BJY, but I truly believe it has forged a veritable army of ideologically sharp, competent and morally upright karyakartas (people of action), who will stand the Congress party in good stead for the next three or four decades. Both Professor Ajay Gudavarthy and Salman Khurshid assert this. The party is undoubtedly in much better shape because of the Yatra. This is an understudied phenomenon, but the BJY disproved the notion that the Congress party's organization was moribund or rotten—to its political allies, the BJP and the nation at large. It has long been theorized that the Congress is ideologically adrift and in terminal decline. On the one hand, this perception could be attributed to the inevitable inertia and disarray that sets in after successive electoral losses. To be fair, there was a moment when the party was so worried about doing the wrong thing that it stopped doing anything at all. Additionally, after serving for decades in governments at multiple levels, the Congress party's primary mode of engagement with the people was through the State. This resulted in a Hamlet-like loss of self-confidence,